

KIAN RAVAEI

**FREEDOM IS
THE THING WITH
FEATHERS**

for wind quintet

(score)

ÆI edition

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I. Bird of Dawn	1
II. Little Sparrow	5
III. Song of the Partridge	13

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Commissioned by WindSync.

PROGRAM NOTE

Songs across cultures and traditions often mention birds in connection with freedom. People have always marveled at these creatures untethered from the earth, symbolizing the possibility of a freer life. Emily Dickinson wrote that “‘Hope’ is the thing with feathers”; I propose that Freedom is also a thing with feathers. Each of the three movements draws from a traditional song, representing a different culture, a different bird, and a different freedom.

The first movement incorporates the traditional Iranian song *Morghe Sahar* (“Bird of Dawn”), composed in 1927 by Iranian classical musician Morteza Neidavoud, with text by Mohammad Taqi-Bahar. It is often regarded as the unofficial anthem for Iranian freedom, thanks in large part to master Iranian vocalist Mohammad Reza Shajarian, who performed *Morghe Sahar* in every concert as a statement against authoritarian rule. The lyrics describe a mournful nightingale, longing to “break and overturn this cage” and “sing the song of human freedom.” Following a melancholy introduction, the “Bird of Dawn” melody is passed between different instruments, concluding with a prayerful chorale setting.

Folklorists recorded “Little Sparrow,” the American ballad featured in the second movement, in early twentieth-century Appalachia. Decades later, musicians and civil rights activists of the American folk music revival, including Bob Dylan, Joan Baez, and Peter, Paul & Mary, would perform the song widely. “I wish I were a little sparrow” sings the narrator, weary of false-hearted men and yearning to “fly away to my true lover.” My setting unfolds as though the narrator is trapped in a cycle, with one instrument playing the melody while the others weave increasingly coarse textures.

Kaqavik (“Partridge”), a 1907 song written by the preeminent Armenian musician Komitas, serves as the basis of the final movement. Komitas’s lifelong pursuit of preserving Armenian folk music was cut short in 1915, after suffering mental trauma in a prison camp during the Armenian Genocide. The lyrics of *Kaqavik*, penned by Armenian national poet Hovhannes Tumanyan, describe a partridge who sings a psalm over the land, “giving heart to the sea of sadness”—a fitting image for Komitas’s legacy. This movement offers a vision of everlasting freedom, combining *Kaqavik*, *Morghe Sahar*, and “Little Sparrow” in jubilant counterpoint.

—Kian Ravaei

duration ca. 13’

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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SONG TRANSCRIPTIONS

Morghe Sahar (Bird of Dawn)

Iranian Traditional (1927)

Melody by Morteza Neidavoud (1900–1990)

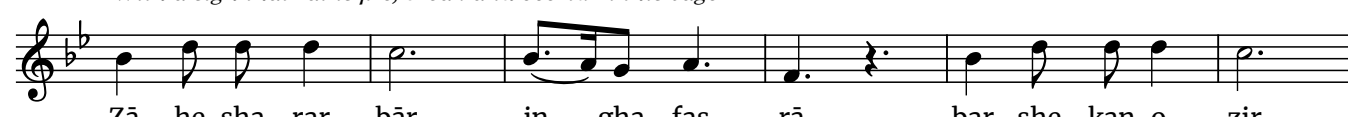
Words by Mohammad-Taqi Bahar (1886–1951)

Bird of dawn, sing your lament. *Renew my pain,*



Mor - ghe sa - har nā - le sar kon Dā - ghe ma - rā tā - ze tar kon

With a sigh that rains fire, break and overturn this cage



Zā - he sha - rar bār in_gha - fas rā bar she - kan o zir

Flightless nightingale, escape from the cage,



o_ze - bar kon Bol - bo - le par bas - te ze kon - je_gha - fas_da - rā

Sing the song of human freedom,



Nagh - me - ye ā - zā - di - ye no - e_ ba - shar_ sar - ā

From the breath of the masses, fill the open earth with fire.



Vaz - na - fas - i ar - se - ye in_ khā - ke too - de rā por sha - rar kon

Little Sparrow

American Traditional (late 19th/early 20th c.)

Anonymous

The musical score for 'Little Sparrow' is written on four staves in 4/4 time, with a key signature of two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The melody is simple and folk-like. The lyrics are: 'I wish I was a lit - tle spar - row, And I had wings and I could fly, I'd fly a - way to my true lo - ver, And all he'd ask I would de - ny.'

I wish I was a lit - tle spar - row,

And I had wings and I could fly,

I'd fly a - way to my true lo - ver,

And all he'd ask I would de - ny.

Kaqavik (Partridge)

Armenian Traditional (1907)

Melody by Komitas (1869–1935)

Words by Hovhannes Tumanyan (1869–1923)

The musical score for 'Kaqavik (Partridge)' is written on three staves in 4/4 time, with a key signature of two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The melody is more complex than the first song, featuring many eighth and sixteenth notes. The lyrics are in Armenian, with English translations above them. The lyrics are: 'When you are perched on a mossy stone, You will sing a psalm to the flowers, Yerb ge gank-nes mam-rod ka - rin, Sagh-mos ga - ses dza - ghi - gne-rin, Spreading cheer to hills and valleys, Giving heart to the sea of sadness. Sa - rer_ dzo-rer z - vart ga - nes, Tar - ti_ dzo-ven sird ge_ ha - nes. Beautiful, beautiful, beautiful, Colorful little partridge. Si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, Nakh-shun ga - ka - vig.'

When you are perched on a mossy stone, *You will sing a psalm to the flowers,*

Yerb ge gank-nes mam-rod ka - rin, Sagh-mos ga - ses dza - ghi - gne-rin,

Spreading cheer to hills and valleys, *Giving heart to the sea of sadness.*

Sa - rer_ dzo-rer z - vart ga - nes, Tar - ti_ dzo-ven sird ge_ ha - nes.

Beautiful, beautiful, beautiful, *Colorful little partridge.*

Si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, Nakh-shun ga - ka - vig.

(All songs are in the public domain.)

(Transposed)

to WindSync

FREEDOM IS THE THING WITH FEATHERS

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(2026)

I. Bird of Dawn

Tranquil ♩ = 48 rit. a tempo

Flute

Oboe

Clarinet (B♭)

Horn (F)

Bassoon

pp warm

p

pp

p warm

pp

3

pp warm

6

3

rit.

a tempo

p

pp

glassy

p

pp

glassy

11

rit.

a tempo

rit.

p

pp

pp

ppp

pp

ppp

pp

ppp

pp

ppp

3

p

pp

ppp

B Maestoso ♩ = 72

air sound with a bit of pitch

(flz.)

17

p percussive, quasi frame drum

f^{heavy}; a rallying cry

(Bird of dawn, sing your lament.)
(Mor - ghe sa - har nă - le sar kon)

f^{heavy}

f^{heavy}

22

pp quasi overtone

p

f^{heavy}

(Renew my pain,)
(Dă - ghe ma - ră tā - ze tar kon)

(With a sigh that rains fire, break and overturn this cage.)
(Ză - he sha - rar bār in gha-fas ră)

27

pp

f

pp cant.

pp cant.

pp

bar she-kan o zir o ze - bar kon)

(Flightless nightingale, escape from the cage.)
(Bol - bo - le par bas - te ze kon -

- je gha - fas da - rā)

32

(Sing the song of human freedom.)
(Nagh - me - ye ā - zā - di - ye no - e ba - shar sar - ā)

pp cant.

pp

36

(From the breath of the masses, fill the open earth with fire.)
(Vaz - na - fas - i ar - se - ye in khā - ke too - de rā por sha - rar kon)

p

p cant.

f

p

f

f

p

f

rit.

D Slightly slower, prayerful $\text{♩} = 66$

41

p

p

p

p

p

48

E

56

64

rit.

Slower, freely $\text{♩} = 58$

$\text{♩} = \text{♩}$

pp

pp

pp

p

pp

pp

fpp

fpp

fpp

fpp

fpp

attacca subito

II. Little Sparrow

Passacaglia: Largo $\text{♩} = 58$

Flute

(*pp*)
(I wish I was a lit - tle spar - row, And I had

Oboe

p heartbroken

Clarinet (Bb)

(*pp*)

Horn (F)

(*pp*)

Bassoon

(*pp*)

8

F

wings and I could fly, I'd fly a - way to my true

2

17

lo - ver, And all he'd ask I would de - ny.)

25 **G**

Measures 25-31. Dynamics: $f > p$, $mf > p$, fp , $f > p$, $mf > fp$.

32

Measures 32-37. Dynamics: $p < mf$, fp , $fp < mf$, fp , $f > p$, fp , mf .

38 **H**

Measures 38-43. Dynamics: pp , $f > p$, pp , f .

44

f $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\rightarrow$ *pp*

f $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\rightarrow$ *pp* *p* forlorn

50 **I**

f $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* *fp* $\leftarrow$ *f* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* *fp*

f $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* *fp* $\leftarrow$ *f* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *p* *fp*

p *p staccatiss.*

56

p $\leftarrow$ *mf* *fp* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *f* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$

p $\leftarrow$ *mf* *fp* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *f* $\rightarrow$ *p* $\rightarrow$ *fp* $\leftarrow$ *mf* $\rightarrow$

62 **K**

pp *f* *p* *pp* *f*

2 3 2 4 4 3

2 2 3 2 2 2

2 2 2 2 2 2

2

68

f *p* *mf* *p* *fp* *mf* *p* *pp*

f *p* *mf* *p* *fp* *mf* *p* *pp*

3 2 3 2

2 2 2 2 2 2

74 **L**

f sharp *f* sharp *f* espr, incisive *f* bold, heroic sharp *f*

3 2 3 2

79

84

84

M

89

89

90

93

N (flz.)

98

ff wild!

ff soulful, wide vib. (quasi flugelhorn)

101

104

107

110

0

The musical score is presented in three systems, each containing four staves. The first system (measures 104-106) features a complex melodic line in the upper staves with frequent slurs and fingerings (2, 5, 4, 2). The lower staves provide a harmonic accompaniment with sustained notes and moving bass lines. The second system (measures 107-109) continues the melodic development with more intricate slurs and fingerings, including a triplet in measure 108. The third system (measures 110-112) concludes the page with a final melodic flourish and a sustained harmonic base. A circled '0' is positioned above the first staff of the third system. The notation is dense, with many beamed sixteenth and thirty-second notes, and various dynamic markings like accents and breath marks.

113

113 114 115

116

116 117 118

119

119 120 121

attacca subito

III. Song of the Partridge

Lively, with bounce ♩ = 88

(When you are perched on a mossy stone,
(Yerb ge gank-nes mam-rod ka - rin,

You will sing a psalm to the flowers,
Sagh-mos ga - ses dza - ghi - gne - rin,

Spreading cheer to hills and valleys,
Sa - rer dzo-rer z - vart

Flute *mf* easygoing

Oboe *pp* transparent

Clarinet (B♭) *pp* transparent

Horn (F) *mf* easygoing *p* *f* *mf*

Bassoon *mf* easygoing *p* *f* *mf*

P

7 ga - nes, Tar - ti dzo-ven sird ge ha - nes. Giving heart to the sea of sadness.

Si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, Beautiful, beautiful, beautiful,

si - ru - nig, Nakh-shun ga - ka - vig. Colorful little partridge.

p *f* *mf* *p* *f* *mf*

14 Beautiful, beautiful, beautiful, Si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, si - ru - nig, Colorful little partridge.)

Nakh-shun ga - ka - vig.) **Q**

p *mf* *mf* easygoing *pp* transparent *f* *p* *f* *mf*

20

System 1 (measures 20-25) features five staves. The top staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat. Measures 20-21 contain eighth-note patterns. Measures 22-23 have a whole rest. Measures 24-25 continue with eighth-note patterns. The second staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a triplet of eighth notes in measure 20. Measures 21-23 have a whole rest. Measures 24-25 have a half note. The third staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. The fourth staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a triplet of eighth notes in measure 20 and a half note in measure 21. Measures 22-23 have a whole rest. Measures 24-25 have a half note. The fifth staff has a bass clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. Dynamics *p*, *f*, and *mf* are indicated at the bottom.

26

R

System 2 (measures 26-31) features five staves. The top staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat. Measures 26-27 have eighth-note patterns. Measures 28-29 have a whole rest. Measures 30-31 continue with eighth-note patterns. The second staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a half note in measure 26. Measures 27-29 have a whole rest. Measures 30-31 have a half note. The third staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. The fourth staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a half note in measure 26. Measures 27-29 have a whole rest. Measures 30-31 have a half note. The fifth staff has a bass clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. Dynamics *p*, *f*, and *mf* are indicated at the bottom.

32

S

System 3 (measures 32-37) features five staves. The top staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat. Measures 32-33 have a whole rest. Measures 34-35 have eighth-note patterns. Measures 36-37 continue with eighth-note patterns. The second staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. The third staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a whole rest in measure 32. Measures 33-35 have a whole rest. Measures 36-37 have a half note. The fourth staff has a treble clef and a key signature of one flat, with a whole rest in measure 32. Measures 33-35 have a whole rest. Measures 36-37 have a half note. The fifth staff has a bass clef and a key signature of one flat, with eighth-note patterns throughout. Dynamics *f*, *p*, and *mf* are indicated at the bottom.

38

f *p* *f* *f* *f* *fp* *f>* *p* *f*

43

T

pp staccatiss. *pp staccatiss.* *f* *pp staccatiss.*

48

ff *pp staccatiss.* *pp sub.* *f*

(flz.)

53 *ff* *p* *mp* *mf* *f*

(ord.)

p *mp* *mf* *f*

59 **U** rit. poco a poco.....

p dolce *pp*

p dolce *pp*

p dolce *pp*

pp *p dolce* *pp*

67 **V** Slower, prayerful ♩ = 72

p *pp* *p* *p*

73

pp

79 W

p

85

rit.

X Bold, triumphant (same tempo)

91

pp

pp

p

pp

f

f

f

f

f

99

sf

sf

sf

sf

sf

sf

sf

sf

sf

Y

107

Y

115 **Z** Slower, freely ♩ = 58 rit.

p *pp* *p* *pp* *p* *pp* *p* *pp*

122 **AA** Jubilant ♩ = 138

p leggiere *mf leggiere* *p leggiere* *p leggiere*

130 **BB**

p *mf* *p leggiere*

138

mf *p* *f* *ff* *mf*

CC

146

mf *f*

154

mf

DD

162

ff *mf* *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf*

168

mf *ff* *mf* *ff* *mf*

174

mf *p* *mf* *ff* *ff* *ff*

180 **EE**

f *ff* *f* *f*

186

f

192 **FF**

ff *p* *p* *p* *p*

198

204 **GG**

210

HH Finale: Vivo (♩ = 138)

216

p

222

p *f* *p* *f*

228 **II**

f *f* *f* *p*

234 KK

p *p* *p* *p* *p*

240

f *p* *f sub.* *p* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f sub.* *p* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f* *p* *ff sub.*
mf *f* *f* *f* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f* *p* *ff sub.*

LL

246

f *p* *f sub.* *p* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f sub.* *p* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f* *p* *ff sub.*
mf *f* *f* *f* *ff sub.*
f *p* *f* *p* *ff sub.*

